and it seems the writer had turned around, because it was in the back, not the chest, that a Bundela spear struck him, so hard that it ‘came out through his breast’.[32] Now – and who can blame him? – Abul Fazl tried to escape; he was riding his horse across a stream, when horse and rider both fell. One of his Abyssinian guards, Jaffar, pulled Abul Fazl out from under his horse and tried to lead him away. But Abul Fazl, speared through his chest and, most likely, injured from the fall, could not walk. He collapsed.

Just then, Bir Singh and his men approached. Jaffar left his lord and hid behind a tree. He watched as the Bundela chief took the historian’s head upon his lap, wiping the mud and sweat off his face with chilling gentleness.

Abul Fazl opened his eyes. ‘The all-conquering lord has sent for you courteously,’ said Bir Singh. It is what Salim had titled himself in Allahabad: world-conqueror, Jahangir. From Asad Beg’s telling, it seems that Bir Singh planned to take Abul Fazl alive – though this hardly matches Salim’s own explicit orders for his assassination.

But Abul Fazl had negotiated with Chand Bibi and climbed the walls of Asirgarh; he had argued with the most powerful scholars in Akbar’s realm and written a prodigious history of his reign; he had ensured his family’s rise and avenged himself on their enemies – he would not succumb to the hired assassin of a dissolute, pleasure-loving prince who gave himself grand names.

Abul Fazl ‘began to abuse [Bir Singh] angrily’, writes Asad Beg. The Bundela king let the proud writer’s head fall back to the ground; he got up and walked away. In his wake, one of his men cut off Abul Fazl’s head.

Some say that when Salim received this grisly prize, he flung it into the toilet.

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Akbar was flying pigeons in Agra fort when he heard what had happened. For over half a century, ever since he escaped his tutors to play with his birds, Akbar had delighted in pigeons trained to swoop or be still at his call. He called it ‘*ishq-baazi*’, it was his love.

Father Monserrate tells of how Akbar’s palaces had separate dwellings for the emperor, his queens, his sons and his pigeons. The priest was as